NLP 245 Project Milestone*

Due: February 17th, 2026 11:59PM

Each team submits one project milestone worth 10% of your overall score. Milestones should be no more than two pages (excluding figures and references); otherwise, we will discount the grades. The milestone should ensure that you are working on your project, practicing your technical writing skills, and receiving feedback on both. This document outlines the information we anticipate you will include in your milestone. In addition, we provide a LaTeX template at `https://www.overleaf.com/read/mnrnckyjsvsn#a63a25`.

1 Milestone Contents (maximum 2 pages)

Your final report will be in the same format as a research paper. We ask that you create a preliminary version of sections of your final report for the milestone. Producing a high-quality milestone is time-consuming, but it will make writing your final report easier. You may find that you can reuse sections of your project proposal in your milestone, but everything should likely be more specific here as you have further developed your project. You should make sure to incorporate any feedback you received in your proposal and/or meetings you've had with the course staff.

Your milestone must be a PDF file created with the provided template. It should be written so that a fellow NLP 245 student can understand it while assuming knowledge from the class. This suggests that you should clearly define the technical terminology. You do not need to clarify the knowledge taught in class. Your milestone can be a maximum of 2 pages (excluding figures and references); note that this means each section must be concise! We recommend you spend less material reintroducing your approach and more space on what you've done and new ideas you've introduced since we use the milestone to evaluate progress. This way, we can also help you decide which directions to take if you're stuck. Your milestone must contain the following sections:

1. **Abstract**: Your abstract should motivate the topic or problem and describe your goals. You should also highlight your main results and insights. Given that your project is still ongoing, it is okay if your results are still in progress. Writing an abstract is challenging since it should be concise, high-level, and convincing. Keep it short!

*Some content is from Stanford CS224n.

2. **Approach**: This section describes how you approach the problem. This is where you, for example, describe your agent architectures, methods, or algorithms.

    - Please be specific when describing your main methods. For example, you may want to include necessary equations and figures (but it is OK to postpone developing figures until the final report).
    - Describe your comparison methods between your approach and related approaches. Depending on space limits and whether your baselines are standard, you may write this down in detail or refer to other papers for details.
    - Make it clear if any part of your approach is novel. Provide references for models and techniques that are not yours.
    - If you are using any code you did not write, make it clear and provide a reference or link. When describing something you implemented yourself, also make it clear.

3. **Experiments**: This section contains the following.

    - **Data**: Provide references for the dataset(s) you are using. Ensure the task associated with the dataset is clearly described.
    - **Evaluation method**: Describe the evaluation metric(s) you adopted, as well as any other details required to understand your evaluation.
    - **Experimental details**: Please describe how you ran your experiments (e.g., model configurations, sampling parameters, etc.). This should be as concise as possible given the space.
    - **Results**: Report your quantitative results so far. To compare several results or baseline methods, use a table or plot.
        - Please provide a discussion on your quantitative results. Are these results expected? Better than you expected? Worse than you expected? What are the reasons leading to the results? What does this tell you about your next steps?
            * We will not take points off for poor method performance. Letting us know where your method is at will instead help us guide you towards changing it for the better. It would be even more helpful if you could point out where the errors are coming from, e.g., in which type of instances we typically see bad performance. However, we encourage follow-ups with course staff to make sure that poor performance is not due to a technical or procedural issue rather than a theoretical one.
        - You do not need to report any qualitative results in the milestone but feel free to if you have time.

4. **Future work**: Describe what you plan to do for the rest of the project and why. You may include specific goals if you like.

5. **References**: Your references section should be produced using BibTeX (following the template), as in all previous assignments.

2 Grading and Feedback

Your milestone will be graded on the criteria below:

1. **Progress**: Has the team made reasonable progress on this project? We expect you to have completed approximately half of the work of the entire project. That may be hard to quantify, but at the base, we are looking for a concrete approach, a code base that can run experiments, and some degree of results.

    - You should have implemented a significant portion of your final method. At the least, you should have obtained early findings that determine whether your method is better than the baselines.
    - Your milestone should show that you have set up your data, comparison or baseline models, and evaluation metrics and conducted experiments to obtain initial results (assuming you are doing a model-relevant project). For many projects, "good progress" relies on various aspects (for example, whether your model is built from scratch or based on an existing codebase). It would help if you established a reasonable goal with your teammates.

2. **Understanding**: Does the milestone show a comprehensive understanding of its problem, tasks, methods, metrics, and research area?

3. **Writing quality**: Does the milestone deliver what you've completed and why, offering the requested information in sufficient detail (given the page limit)? Is the writing logical, concise when necessary, and obeys the general conventions of technical writing? Are there no grammatical errors?

3 Tips for Technical Writing

In general, technical writing is an essential skill in this class, as well as in research and beyond. Therefore, it is worth your effort to improve your writing to communicate technical concepts clearly. **Please do not use LLMs like ChatGPT to write your paper**. We want the writing to be primarily yours so you can gain skills in technical writing; also, LLMs will often have a far different tone than desired unless a lot of effort is put into prompting. Proofreading is key. We've noticed in past assignments many unclear sections or parts with misspellings. It is in everyone's interest for the writing to be of high quality so it can be used in the final paper with minimal adjustment. Here are some resources that may help improve your technical writing:

- Tips for Writing Technical Papers, Jennifer Widom.
- Write the Paper First, Jason Eisner.
- Writing in the Sciences, Coursera course.

Here are some other things you can do to improve your technical writing:

- Look carefully at multiple NLP papers to understand the typical writing structure, style, and content of different sections. Build your writing model on these examples.
- Revisit the NLP papers you've already read (for example, the paper summary in your proposal). Which parts are easy or difficult to follow and why? Can you figure out any good writing practices that you might use for your writing?
- Print your writing, read it in your head or aloud to yourself, and go through it with a pen to mark any changes you see the need to make.
- Ask a friend to read your writing and tell you whether it is clear. This can be helpful even if your friends do not have the relevant technical background.
- All of the course staff are happy to discuss best practices in technical writing. We encourage you to meet with us and bring a draft of your project milestone to get feedback.

4 Submission Instructions

Submit your PDF on Canvas as before.